Xinyi Wang, PhD

The Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania
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Academic Employment

Postdoctoral Research Fellow July 2025 – Current
Health Communication & Equity Lab,
Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania

Education

Ph.D. Communication May 2025
Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania
Dissertation: *Investigating Environmental and Biological Factors that Shape Our Curiosity for New Information*
Committee: Dr. David Lydon-Staley (chair), Dr. Emily Falk, Dr. Andy Tan

M.A. Statistics and Data Science Dec. 2024
The Wharton School, University of Pennsylvania
Thesis: *A Socioemotional Network Perspective on Momentary Experiences of Family Conflict in Young Adults*

M.A. Journalism and Mass Communication May 2020
School of Journalism and Mass Communication, University of Wisconsin – Madison
Thesis: *Beneficial or Harmful: Does Peer Marijuana Expectancy Influence Norm Perception and Use Intent*
Committee: Dr. Dhavan V. Shah (advisor); Dr. Chris N. Cascio

B.A. Journalism and Mass Communication May 2018
School of Journalism and Mass Communication, University of Wisconsin – Madison

Grants and Awards

Annenberg Public Policy Center ($10,000) Under Review
- **Project Title:** Ask, Trust, Verify: Civic and Health Information-Seeking Behavior in Conversational AI-systems
- **Role: PI**, University of Pennsylvania

Center for Coordination of Analytics, Science, Enhancement, and Logistics in Tobacco Regulatory Science ($150,000) Under Review
CASEL Opportunity Fund

- **Project Title:** Feasibility and Preliminary Effectiveness Study of LLM-Tailored Tobacco Continuum of Risk Messaging Among Adults Who Use Cigarettes
- **Role: PI**, University of Pennsylvania

National Cancer Institute of the National Institutes of Health 07/2025 - Present
U01CA294539

- **Project Title:** From Perceptions to Behaviors: A Comprehensive Approach to Examine the Impact of Public Health Communication Messaging about the Continuum of Risk for Tobacco Products
- **Role: Postdoctoral Research Fellow**, University of Pennsylvania

Health Equity Network Travel Award ($1400) 2026
Society for Research on Nicotine and Tobacco

Dissertation Research Fund ($1200) 2024
University of Pennsylvania

CETLI Teaching Certificate 2024
University of Pennsylvania

GAPSA Student Service Award ($3400) 2023/2024
University of Pennsylvania

Top Paper Award 2020
International Communication Association CommSciBio Group

Technology Grant ($500) 2020
University of Pennsylvania

Student Research Grant Competition ($1000) 2019
University of Wisconsin-Madison

Graduate Student Research Grant ($1200) 2019
University of Wisconsin-Madison

Dean's List 2015 – 2018
University of Wisconsin-Madison

Fellowship

Penn Climate Scholars Fellowship 08/2026 - Present
University of Pennsylvania

Publications

Peer-reviewed Journal Articles

1. **Wang, X.,** Muzekari, B., Lew, T., Fishman, J., Cinquegrani, M., Mercincavage, M., Tan, ASL., Lydon-Staley, D.M. Intellectual humility and learning outcomes in online health information-seeking (In Press). *Health Communication*

2. Zhang, Y., Saladin, K., **Wang, X.**, Tfayli, D., Moran, M.B., Tan, A.S.L. Communicating the nicotine and tobacco risk continuum: a scoping review and framework for future messaging. *Nicotine & Tobacco Research, ntag234.* https://doi.org/10.1093/ntr/ntag234

3. Monami, N., **Wang, X.,** Cornblath, E.J, Lee, S., Shih, Y., Palomero-Gallagher, N., Arcaro, M., Lydon-Staley, D.M, & Mackey, A. (2026). Alcohol impacts an fMRI marker of neural inhibition in humans and rodents. *NeuroImage,* 121899. 10.1016/j.neuroimage.2026.121899

4. **Wang, X.,** Muzekari, B., Mercincavage, M., Tan, A. S., & Lydon-Staley, D. M. (2025). Targeting three United States priority populations of people who smoke with educational nicotine messages using curiosity-eliciting strategies. *Scientific Reports*, 15(1), 23203. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-025-04050-z

5. **Wang, X.,** McGowan, A.L., Fosco, G.M., Falk, E.B., Bassett, D.S., & Lydon-Staley, D.M. (2024). A socioemotional network perspective on momentary experiences of family conflict in young adults. *Family Process,* 1-16. https://doi.org/10.1111/famp.12995

6. Clark, J., Vincent, A., **Wang, X.**, McGowan, A.L., & Lydon-Staley, D.M. (2023). Smokers' curiosity for tobacco-related trivia aids recall of tobacco-related information. *Health Communication*, *38*(14), 3357-3365. https://doi.org/10.1080/10410236.2022.2149098

7. Tao, R., **Wang, X.**, Wang, Y., Yao, H., Wu, S., Liu, J., Yang, S. (2023). Emotional appeals and norms: how normative perceptions moderate the persuasive impacts of discrete emotional appeals within tobacco pictorial warnings in China. *Health Communication,* 1-16. https://doi.org/10.1080/10410236.2023.2277036

8. **Wang, X.**, Dworkin, J.D., Zhou, D., Stiso, J., Falk, E.B., Bassett, D.S., Zurn, P., & Lydon-Staley, D.M. (2021). Gendered citation practices in the field of communication. *Annals of the International Communication Association, 45,* 134-153. https://doi.org/10.1080/23808985.2021.1960180

Book Chapters

9. **Wang, X.,** Scholz, C., Falk, E. B., & Lydon-Staley, D. M. (2023). Neuroimaging. In E. Y. Ho, C. L. Bylund, & J. C. M. van Weert (Eds.), *The International Encyclopedia of Health Communication* (Vol. 4). (The Wiley Blackwell-ICA International Encyclopedias of Communication series). Wiley Blackwell. https://doi.org/10.1002/9781119678816.iehc0600

Manuscripts Under Peer Review

10. **Wang, X.,** Devkota, J., Saladin, K., Audrain-McGovern, J., Cohen, J., Strasser, A., Strickland, J., Thrul. J., Moran, M., Tan, A.S.L. SMART(Select Messages Via Attribute-Based Ranking And Testing) framework: a case study of tobacco continuum of risk message formative research. Preprint: https://osf.io/preprints/socarxiv/d2v8y_v1

11. **Wang, X.**, Falk, E.B., Lydon-Staley, D.M. Using social signals communicating information value to change curiosity. Preprint: https://osf.io/preprints/psyarxiv/268pd_v2

12. Mclain, C., Hanby, E., Okker-Edging, K., Gordon, B., Katz-wise, S., Salloum, R., Liu, S., Pilla, J., Saladin, K., **Wang, X.**, Ye, Q., & Tan, A.S.L. Amplifying LGBTO+ youth voices: a community-centered research approach to reducing vaping in LGBTQ+ youth populations.

Manuscripts in Preparation

1. **Wang, X.,** Mclain, C., Devkota, J., Saladin, K., Audrain-McGovern, J., Cohen, J., Strasser, A., Strickland, J., Thrul. J., Moran, M., Tan, A.S.L. Divergent effects of chemicals and switching contents on perceptions of continuum of risk tobacco messaging: a mixed methods study.

2. **Wang, X.,** Huang, S. Intellectual humility and learning outcomes of health and science questions through AI-generated summaries.

3. Ye, Q., **Wang, X.,** Moran, M.B., Tan, A.S.L. Large language models as human evaluations for health message selection: the roles of prompting strategy and model size.

4. Rabayda, C., **Wang, X.,** Devkota, J., Saladin, K., Audrain-McGovern, J., Cohen, J., Strasser, A., Strickland, J., Thrul. J., Moran, M., Tan, A.S.L. Annoyance toward messages about the nicotine and tobacco product continuum of risk among U.S. adults who use cigarettes.

5. Chew, F., **Wang, X.,** Devkota, J., Saladin, K., Audrain-McGovern, J., Cohen, J., Strasser, A., Strickland, J., Thrul. J., Moran, M., Tan, A.S.L. Quit attempt history, intention to quit, and effects perceptions of FDA messages about switching from cigarettes to e-cigarettes, smokeless tobacco, or nicotine pouches.

Conference Presentations

Paper Presentations

1. Ye, Q., **Wang, X.,** Moran, M.B., Tan, A.S.L. (September 2026). Large language models as human evaluations for health message selection: the roles of prompting strategy and model size. *Communication Science Futures*.
2. Lyew, T., **Wang, X.**, Falk, E.B., Lydon-Staley, D.M. (April 2026). Curiosity and memory retention: the benefit of sharing knowledge. *Society for Affective Science*.
3. Zhang, Y., Saladin, K., **Wang, X.**, Tfayli, D., Moran, M.B., Tan, A.S.L. (March 2026). Communicating the nicotine and tobacco risk continuum: a scoping review and framework for future messaging. *Society for Research on Nicotine and Tobacco*.
4. **Wang, X.,** Muzekari, B., Lyew, T., Fishman, J., Cinquegrani, M., Tan, A.S.L., & Mercincavage, M., Lydon-Staley, D.M. (June 2025). Fluctuations in curiosity and time spent searching for health-related information online. *Annual International Communication Association Conference*.
5. Anh, C*., **Wang, X*.**, González-Bailón, S. (July 2023). Performative capitalism in silicon valley: examining performative and substantive political behaviors of u.s. technology companies. *9th International Conference on Computational Social Science*. * indicates co-first authorship ***Plenary Talk***
6. **Wang, X.,** Falk, E.B., Lydon-Staley, D.M. (May 2023). Using social signals communicating information value to change curiosity. *Annual International Communication Association Conference*.
7. **Wang, X.**, McGowan, A.L., Fosco, G.M., Falk, E.B., Bassett, D.S., & Lydon-Staley, D.M. (May 2022). A socioemotional network perspective on momentary experiences of family conflict in young adults. *Annual International Communication Association Conference*.
8. **Wang, X.**, Dworkin, J.D., Zhou, D., Stiso, J., Falk, E.B., Bassett, D.S., Zurn, P., & Lydon-Staley, D.M. (May 2021). Gendered citation practices in the field of communication. *Annual International Communication Association Conference*. ***Top Paper Award***
9. Tveleneva, A., **Wang, X.**, Cascio, C.N., O'Donnell, M.B., Falk, E.B. (May 2020) The relationship between self-construal and neural processes associated with conformity. *Annual International Communication Association Conference*.
10. Hills, O., **Wang, X.** (May 2019). Elders, depression, and social networking: understanding who benefits the most from an online social support system. *Annual International Communication Association Conference*.

Poster Presentations

11. **Wang, X.,** Muzekari, B., Lyew, T., Fishman, J., Cinquegrani, M., Tan, ASL., Mercincavage, M., Lydon-Staley, D.M. (September 2026). Intellectual humility and learning outcomes in online health information-seeking. *Communication Science Futures*.
12. **Wang, X.**, Devkota, J., Tfayli, D., Saladin, K., Jackson, J., Moran, M., Tan, A. (July 2026). How message themes influence perceived effectiveness of continuum of risk messaging among u.s. adults who use cigarettes. *NIH Tobacco Regulatory Science Meeting*.

13. **Wang, X.**, Devkota, J., Saladin, K., Moran, M., Tan, A. (March 2026). Selecting tobacco health message: a novel application of multi-attribute decision modeling. *Society for Research on Nicotine and Tobacco*.

14. **Wang, X.**, Muzekari, B., Mercincavage, M., Tan, A.S., Lydon-Staley, D.M. (March 2025). Targeting three United States priority populations with educational nicotine messages using curiosity-eliciting strategies. *Society for Research on Nicotine and Tobacco*.

15. Yang, E.F., Shah, D.V., Sethares, W.A., Sun, S.G., **Wang, X.** (July 2019). Classification algorithms for modeling categorical dependent variables: a study of online health information seeking. *5th International Conference on Computational Social Science*.

16. **Wang, X.**, Cascio, C.N., O'Donnell, M.B., Falk, E.B. (April 2019). Social norms: the neural relationship between social feedback and observing social norms. *Social & Affective Neuroscience Society*.

Moderator

17. Top Refereed Research Paper Session (Aug. 2025). Communicating Science, Health, Environment and Risk Division. *The Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication*

Teaching

Undergraduate Level Class
Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania

- **COMM125 Introduction to Communication Behavior** Spring 2023
  Teaching Assistant for Yphtach Lelkes, 15 students
  Topics: media effects, attitude and persuasion, misinformation, research design, data analysis

- **COMM225 Children and Media** Fall 2022
  Teaching Assistant for Kimberly D. Woolf, 75 students
  Topics: cognitive development, gender and children, mental health, social behavior

Undergraduate Level Class
School of Journalism and Mass Communication, University of Wisconsin – Madison

- **Journalism 202 Mass Communication Practices** Fall 2019/Spring 2020
  Teaching Assistant for Stacy Forster, 15 students
  Topics: journalism practices, public relations, marketing, media planning and buying

- **Journalism 201**

Introduction to Journalism and Communication Fall 2018/Spring 2019
Teaching Assistant for Kathleen Culver, 15 students
Topics: news and new media, strategic communication, global media systems, media effects

Summer Institute in Computational Social Science Summer 2021
University of Pennsylvania
Teaching Assistant for Xi Song, Tian Yang, Yuan Yuan

Course Design Institute Summer 2025
Center for Excellence in Teaching, Learning and Innovation, University of Pennsylvania

Mentoring Experience

Penn Undergraduate Research Mentoring Program Summer 2026
Health Communication and Equity Lab, University of Pennsylvania

- **Mentee: James Xiaoxing Wan**
  Project Title: 'A Due Diligence to Let Us Know': Trust in Tobacco Health Information Sources for Continuum of Risk Messaging Among U.S. Adults who Smoke

- **Mentee: Hannah Feldschreiber**
  Project Title: What's so Annoying? Examining Annoyance in Continuum of Risk Messaging Among U.S. Adults who Smoke Cigarettes

Graduate Students
Health Communication and Equity Lab, University of Pennsylvania Fall 2025 - Current

- Fengyi Chew
- Cecilia Rabayda
- Ying Zhang

MindCORE's Step-Ahead Mentorship Program Fall 2020
University of Pennsylvania

- Mentored undergraduate students for graduate school application

Invited Talks

University of Texas - Austin
- Investigating Time and Within-person Change in Communication Fall 2026
  Invited by Shengchun Huang

University of Utah Health Academic Medical Center

- Curiosity As Messaging Strategy: Targeting Three United States Priority Populations With Education Nicotine Messages — Summer 2026
  Invited by Andy King

University of California - Davis

- Foraging Information: Curiosity and Communication Research
  Invited by Seth Frey — Spring 2026

University of California - Santa Barbara

- Emotion and Health — Spring 2026
  Invited by Jiaying Liu

University of Pennsylvania

- Experiments in Communication — Fall 2025
  Invited by Andy Tan

- Social Media, Habit and the Brain — Spring 2023
  Invited by Yphtach Lelkes

- Race and Children's Media — Fall 2023
  Invited by Kimberly D. Woolf

Research Experience

University of Pennsylvania

Health Communication and Equity Lab — July 2025 – Current
Postdoctoral Research Fellow
PI: Dr. Andy Tan

Addiction, Health, & Adolescent (AHA!) Lab — Sept. 2020 – May 2025
Graduate Research Assistant
PI: Dr. David Lydon-Staley

University of Wisconsin-Madison

Communication, Brain and Behavior (CBB) Lab — Sept. 2018 – May 2020
Graduate Research Assistant
PI: Dr. Chris N. Cascio

Health Information Technology Studies (HITS) Group — Jan. 2017 – May 2020
Graduate Research Assistant
PI: Dr. Dhavan V. Shah

Center for Communication Research Jan. 2017 – May 2018
Undergraduate Research Assistant
PI: Dr. Catalina Toma

Workshops

Qualitative Institute 2025
Thomas Jefferson University

fNIRS Summer School 2025
Washington University in St. Louis

Intensive Longitudinal Methods Workshop 2022
Cornell University

Summer Institute in Computational Social Science 2021
University of Pennsylvania

Summer Institute on Addiction 2019
University of Amsterdam

Service

Ad Hoc Reviewer
Journals: Scientific Report, Health Communication
Conferences: ICA (2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025), NCA (2024), SRNT (2025, 2026)

Chair
Conversation Series Planning Committee 2025 – 2026
Health Communication Division,
International Communication Association

Social Media Coordinator 2025 – Current
Communication Science and Biology Interest Group,
International Communication Association

Operations Coordinator 2025 – Current
Health Equity Network Communications Committee,
Society for Research on Nicotine & Tobacco

Member 2025
MindCore DivE IN Mentorship Weekend Communications Team,
University of Pennsylvania

Director of External Affairs 2023 – 2024

Advocacy Division, Graduate and Professional Student Assembly,
University of Pennsylvania

General Assembly Member 2020 – 2022
Graduate and Professional Student Assembly,
University of Pennsylvania

Graduate Council Member 2020 – 2021
Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania

References

David Lydon-Staley
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Associate Professor
Annenberg School for Communication,
University of Pennsylvania

Emily Falk
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Professor
Annenberg School for Communication,
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Andy Tan
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Associate Professor
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University of Pennsylvania

Meghan Moran
mmoran22@jhu.edu
Associate Professor
Bloomberg School of Public Health,
Johns Hopkins University